governance); ‘our youth are not snake charmers, they are changing the world with a mouse’; ‘our biggest national resource are our people. Made in India must become our biggest brand.’ Each statement echoed a sense of looking forward. In a climate of negativity and pessimism, it appeared to strike just the right chord for a young audience that frequently broke into applause.

There was also a fair amount of hyperbole, especially when ‘selling’ Gujarat. ‘There must be no one in the audience who has chai without *doodh* from Gujarat in it. All the milk in Delhi is from Gujarat. Milk in Singapore is from Gujarat. Okra in Europe is from Gujarat. Tomatoes in Afghanistan are from Gujarat. The bhindi you eat is from Gujarat!’ he claimed. Of course, what he conveniently did not mention was that it was a certain Dr Verghese Kurien and his Amul milk cooperative dream that ushered in Gujarat’s White Revolution and not Mr Modi. The students did not seem to mind, though. Modi’s public-speaking skills had won them over.

It wasn’t just the students—the media also lapped up Modi’s performance. All national and several regional channels carried Modi’s speech ‘live’. Next morning, every national newspaper had Modi as a front-page headline. ‘Modi takes Delhi by storm,’ declared the *Times of India*. The only paper not to carry Modi’s speech on the front page was *The Hindu*; it was also the only paper to give equal coverage to anti-Modi protests organized by left students’ groups outside SRCC. Its then editor Siddharth Varadarajan defended his decision by claiming that Modi, after all, was just another chief minister who had come to Delhi—why should it make a top headline? His was a lonely voice.

Modi and his team were thrilled by the response. They felt that the SRCC speech had not just captured the youth’s focus but had also been able to reach out to thought leaders and the urban middle class through the power of live television. ‘We realized that Modi was unbeatable in a town hall format. We had also managed to create just the right amount of buzz in the media and among opinion makers,’ said a Modi strategist.

I spoke to Modi on the phone a few days after the SRCC speech (I would usually call him up late night or on a Sunday morning when he was